man.'[13] This is indeed true, as almost all his biographers have noted. Nevertheless, it is also true that translating this vision into policy meant leaving the world of visions and interacting with the more mundane world of politics, where arguments and alternatives put forward by his contemporaries had to be disarmed (or often dismissed), opponents confronted and outmanoeuvred, compromises struck, choices made, events responded to and, more importantly, Nehru's own grip on political power enhanced.

It is equally true that Nehru's personality, complex and contradictory in equal measure, heavily influenced his politics. Combining hard work, charm, idealism and ruthlessness with vanity, petulance and frequent (and famous) outbursts of temper,[14] Nehru's predilections and prejudices, his likes and dislikes, had a great bearing on his relationships with his contemporaries, and his engagement with their ideas. Nehru's political career was rooted not only in his vision, but also in the exigencies of practical politics and the personal relationships he shared – an aspect of his politics that admirers tend to play down as much as detractors like to play up.

In this setting, engagement with other political actors was as instrumental as it was ideational, and as personal as it was public. If Nehru the visionary was an idealist, then Nehru the political actor was as much a hard-nosed realist. Nehru's vision is part of the story; so is the intersection of his vision with the wider political world he operated in. Nehru's writings and public utterances accordingly have to be seen in this light – as tools of both intellectual and strategic engagement with other political actors, and as a method of positioning himself in and navigating through the fraught politics of the pre-Nehruana years. Appreciating the origins and power of Nehru's vision of India – which, as Brown contends, is essential for an understanding of the man – thus must be complemented by an appreciation for, and an understanding of, how that vision emerged at the intersection of Nehru's ideas, the ideas of his contemporaries, the vagaries of practical politics and the foibles of Nehru's own personality. Examining his debates enables us to do this.